

Abortion Opinion, 1980-2024

The most recent study first, and the fifty years underneath it

84-355 Democracy's Data

August 2026

This chapter runs backwards from the usual order. It begins with what Americans said in the most recent study, then splits that by the two identities the companion chapters built, and only then asks what moved. The reason is that a trend line is unreadable until you know what a single row means.

It also depends on those two chapters rather than repeating them. Party identification is kept at seven points because the party-id chapter shows that collapsing it is where the leaners disappear. Ideological self-placement keeps the people who said *haven't thought much about it* as their own group, because the ideology chapter shows the codebook files that answer under **Valid**.

01 What Americans said in 2024

The option as read	Respondents	Share
Never permitted	293	5.8%
Only for rape, incest, or danger to the woman's life	1,166	23.2%
Other reasons, but only after the need is established	1,059	21.1%
Always, as a matter of personal choice	2,503	49.9%

Half of the people asked, 49.9%, take the fourth option: abortion as a matter of personal choice. 5.8% take the first, never permitted.

The interesting one is the third. Read it again as the respondent hears it:

The respondent is handed a booklet and asked which opinion best agrees with their view. The four options, verbatim:

- 1 By law, abortion should never be permitted.
- 2 The law should permit abortion only in case of rape, incest, or when the woman's life is in danger.
- 3 The law should permit abortion for reasons other than rape, incest, or danger to the woman's life, but only after the need for the abortion has been clearly established.
- 4 By law, a woman should always be able to obtain an abortion as

a matter of personal choice.

9 DK; other

Five random rows from the 2024 study, with the two identity columns this chapter uses alongside:

year	VCF0838	VCF0301	VCF0803	abortion_view
2024	3	3	5	Other reasons, but only after the
2024	3	3	4	Other reasons, but only after the
2024	4	1	2	Always, as a matter of personal ch
2024	4	1	1	Always, as a matter of personal ch
2024	4	2	4	Always, as a matter of personal ch

Option 3 is the one to watch. It is not a middle position between 1 and 4 -- it is a permission with a gatekeeper, and it is where the movement of the last four years went.

Option 3 is not a midpoint between never and always. It is a *permission with a gatekeeper* — abortion allowed, but only once someone has established that the need is real. A person choosing it has not split the difference; they have chosen a procedural answer to a question the other three options answer in principle. Keep it in view: it is where the last four years went.

02 The same study, by party

Party identification	Respondents	Never	Rape incest life	Need established	Always
Strong Democrat	1,207	1.4%	6.7%	12.8%	79.0%
Weak Democrat	582	1.9%	8.8%	18.7%	70.6%
Independent-Democrat	670	1.5%	8.1%	20.1%	70.3%
Independent-Independent	330	5.5%	19.1%	23.3%	52.1%
Independent-Republican	624	8.5%	38.5%	27.2%	25.8%
Weak Republican	524	7.6%	34.5%	27.7%	30.2%
Strong Republican	1,059	13.2%	46.3%	24.8%	15.7%

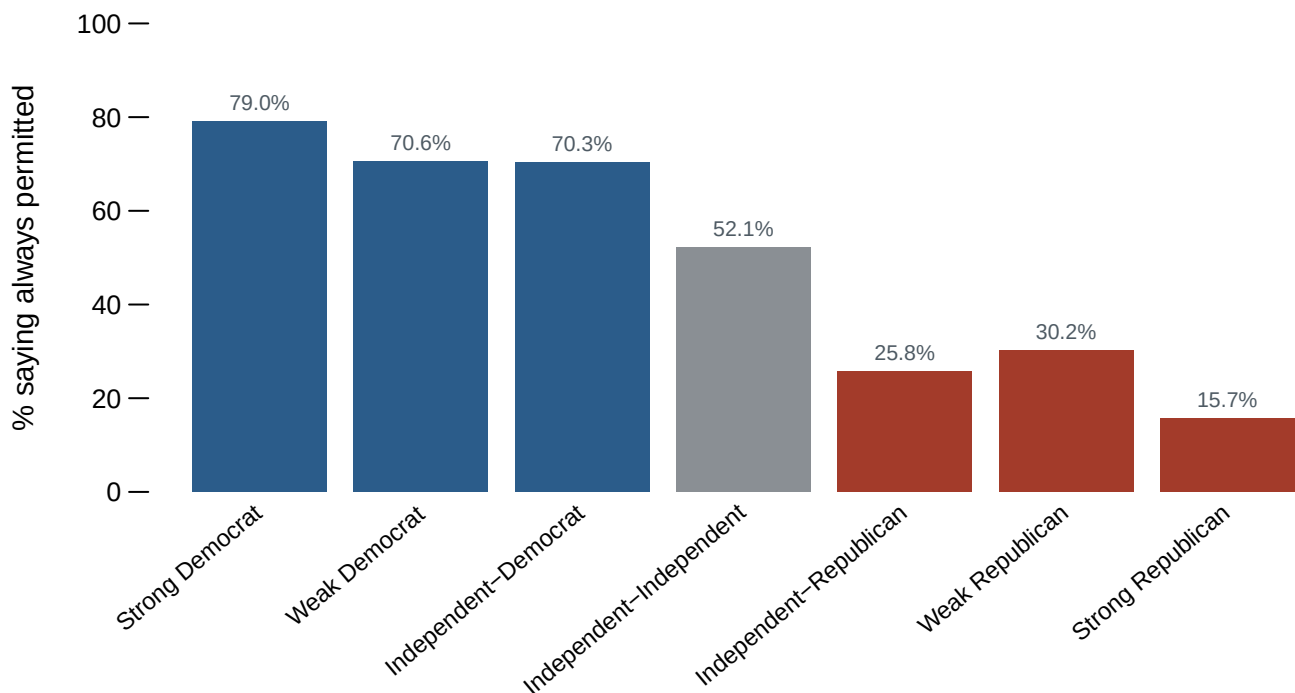


Figure 1. The seven-point party scale against the abortion item, most recent study. The buttons switch which of the four options is drawn; hovering a bar gives that group's whole distribution and its number of respondents. Option 4 is the one that gets reported, and the leaners are the third and fifth bars. Switch between the options and watch how much of the party gradient each one carries: Option 4 runs from 15.7% to 79.0%, a spread of 63.3 points. Option 3 runs only from 12.8% to 27.7%, which is 14.9 points. The gatekeeper answer is not flat across the scale, but it is roughly a quarter as steep, which is how it can absorb movement without registering as a partisan story.

The gradient runs the way you would expect, with one thing worth stopping on. **Leaning Republicans are further from the pro-choice position than weak Republicans**, at 25.8% against 30.2%. The people who decline the party label hold the more conservative view on this issue than the people who accept it. That is the same pattern the party-id chapter found in vote choice, showing up in a second place.

Fold the leaners into "independent," as the file's own three-category column invites you to do, and you would report an independent group sitting near 52.1% while the actual unaf-

filiated middle is a much smaller group. The choice made two chapters ago changes what this table says.

03 The same study, by ideology

Ideological self placement	Respondents	Never	Need established	Always
Extremely liberal	235	3.8%	4.7%	88.1%
Liberal	758	0.8%	9.2%	86.3%
Slightly liberal	515	1.4%	20.2%	72.4%
Moderate, middle of the road	1,085	2.6%	25.8%	54.0%
Slightly conservative	532	4.9%	31.4%	34.2%
Conservative	928	9.9%	26.2%	15.1%
Extremely conservative	278	27.7%	13.3%	12.6%
Haven't thought much about it	679	7.1%	21.5%	47.1%

Ideology sorts abortion opinion more sharply than party does, from 88.1% among the extremely liberal to 12.6% among the extremely conservative.

Now the row that only exists because the ideology chapter refused to throw it away. People who said they **haven't thought much about** liberal and conservative are 47.1% in favour of the always option. That sits between moderates (54.0%) and the slightly conservative (34.2%), and nowhere near the midpoint of the scale.

They have a position. They have a fairly definite one. What they decline is the *vocabulary*. A common habit, dropping them as missing, would have removed 679 people with opinions from a table about opinions.

Before you read on, commit to a view. The party gradient and the ideology gradient both look strong. **Which of the two do you expect was already strong in 1980, and which one had to be built?** Write down your answer.

04 What moved

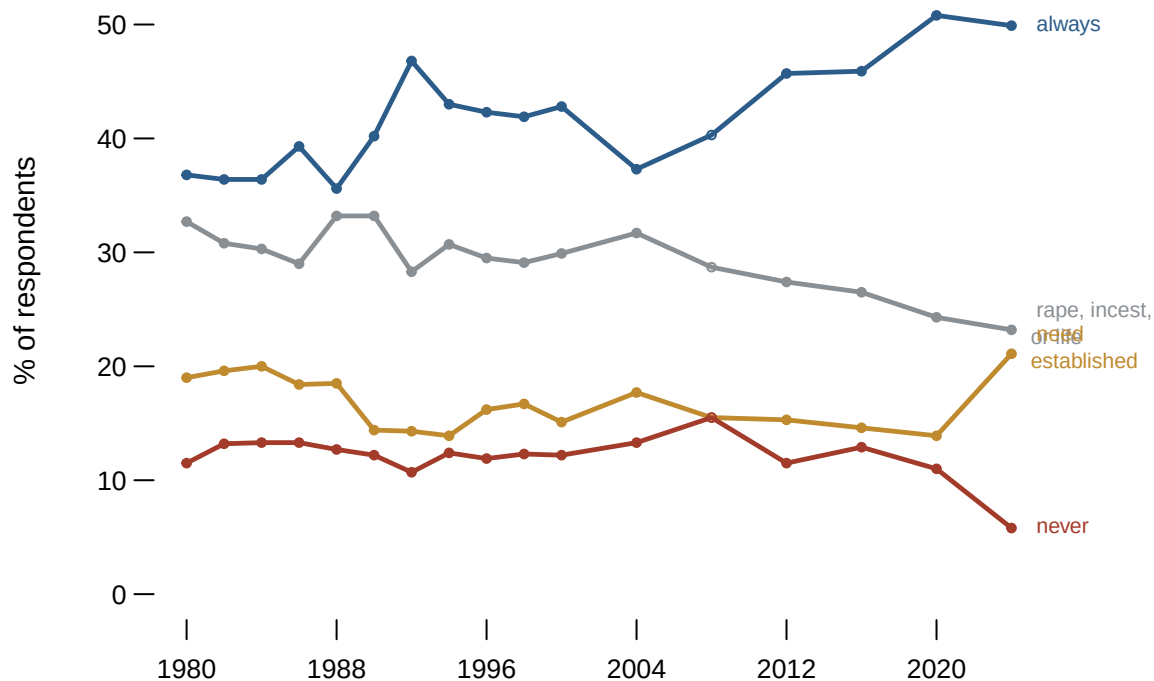


Figure 2. All four options, every study year in which the item was asked. Scrub across the plot to read all four shares at any year. The buttons below mute a series so the remaining ones can be compared without it. Hollow points mark 2008, where a documented split half-sample leaves the item largely missing, at 55.3% missing that year. The line is drawn through it rather than bridged silently, because a gap that has been filled in looks exactly like data.

The top line is the one that gets reported, and it is the one that has moved least. *Always permitted* was 36.8% in 1980 and 49.9% in 2024 — a rise of 13.1 points across forty-four years, most of it arriving by the early 1990s.

Underneath, between 2020 and 2024:

Option	Then	Now	Change
Never permitted	11.0%	5.8%	-5.2
Only rape, incest, or life	24.3%	23.2%	-1.1
Only after the need is established	13.9%	21.1%	+7.2
Always, personal choice	50.8%	49.9%	-0.9

The absolutist position roughly halved, and the mass did not go to the opposite pole — *always permitted* fell slightly. It went into option 3, the permission with a gatekeeper, which gained 7.2 points.

A reader watching only the headline number would conclude that nothing much happened between 2020 and 2024. Something quite large happened, and it happened in the categories nobody reports.

05 The gaps that had to be built

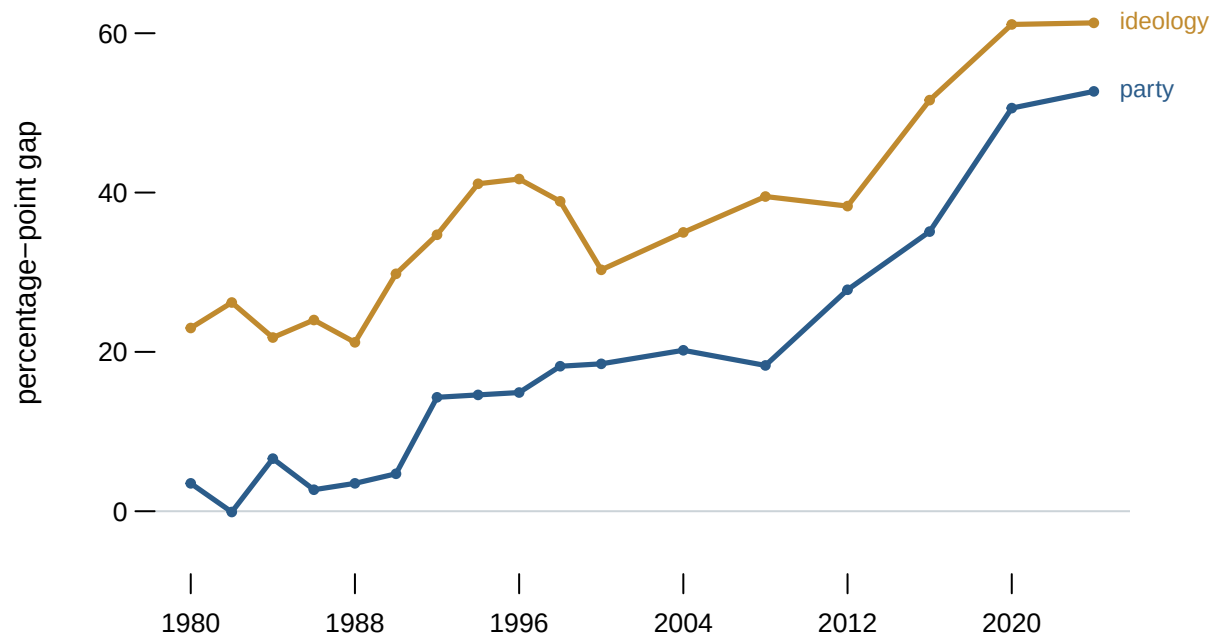


Figure 3. The party gap and the ideology gap in the share saying always permitted.

Democrats minus Republicans, leaners included on both sides; liberals minus conservatives. Higher means the two groups are further apart. Hovering reports the four shares behind the two differences, which is where the interesting part is.

Between 1980 and 2024 the Democratic share saying *always* rose by 37.4 points. The Republican share fell by 11.8. The gap widened mostly because one side moved.

In 1980 the party gap on abortion was **3.5 points**. Democrats and Republicans held almost the same distribution of views. Abortion was an issue that cut across the parties rather than between them.

By 2024 the gap is **52.7 points**.

The ideology gap started higher, at 23.0 points in 1980. Liberal and conservative already meant something about abortion when the party labels did not. It too widened, to 61.3.

This is the finding the chapter's order was designed to deliver. The aggregate looks like a country whose mind changed slowly. Split it by party and you see a country whose mind changed much less than its *sorting* did: roughly the same distribution of opinions, redistributed onto different teams.

06 What this chapter cannot tell you

2008 is 55.3% missing on this item, and that is documented rather than broken: a random half sample received a branching series of questions instead of the four-option card. Read the codebook note and your sample is halved for a known reason; miss it and 2008 looks like a collapse in response. The year is kept in the figures and drawn hollow rather than dropped.

Four options are not a scale. The distance from *never* to *rape, incest or life* is not the same quantity as the distance from *need established* to *always*, so this chapter reports

shares and differences of shares, and never a mean. A mean of these four numbers would be arithmetic on labels.

Nothing here is weighted; VCF0009z sits in the file unused, so every percentage describes ANES respondents rather than the country.

The 2020-to-2024 movement invites a *Dobbs* story and this chapter does not tell one. Two studies four years apart cannot separate a decision's effect from everything else that happened, and the codebook records no wording change that would explain it either. What can be said is what the table says: the movement was out of the absolute prohibition and into the conditional permission, and not toward personal choice.

Finally, the party and ideology gradients are not independent of each other, and this chapter does not try to hold one constant while varying the other. Which of the two is doing the work is a real question and a different chapter.

07 Sources

- American National Election Studies. *ANES Time Series Cumulative Data File (1948–2024)*, version of 5 February 2026. Ann Arbor, MI and Palo Alto, CA: University of Michigan and Stanford University. <https://electionstudies.org/data-center/anes-time-series-cumulative-data-file/>
- ANES. *Time Series Cumulative Data File Codebook*, same release. The four options and the 2008 split-sample note are quoted from it directly.
- Adams, Greg D. (1997). "Abortion: Evidence of an Issue Evolution." *American Journal of Political Science* 41(3): 718–737.
- Carmines, Edward G. and James A. Stimson (1989). *Issue Evolution: Race and the Transformation of American Politics*. Princeton University Press.
- Layman, Geoffrey C. (2001). *The Great Divide: Religious and Cultural Conflict in American Party Politics*. Columbia University Press.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`by_ideology.csv`, `by_party.csv`, `gaps.csv`, `now.csv`, `overtime.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `overtime.csv` runs the same four answer categories across the whole series. Find the year each one peaks. Does the country look like it changed its mind, or like it stayed still?
- `gaps.csv` carries both `party_gap` and `ideology_gap` for every year. Plot them together. Which one opened first, and which is wider now?
- `overtime.csv` has a `pct_missing` column. Find the years where it is highest. Does a question get harder to answer when the politics get hotter?
- `by_party.csv` and `by_ideology.csv` split the most recent study two ways. Which split separates people more cleanly? Then ask which one a pollster would rather report.